Capacity-feasible CVRP clustering on an analog neutral-atom register (Track A)

Pasqal challenge — team DuQuantum — repository ‘qhack‘

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1. Model

What we chose, why, and what it costs. Cluster-first / route-second: the register decides *which* customers share a vehicle; each cluster is then routed exactly (Held–Karp, `cvrp/common.py`). The full (customer, vehicle, position) encoding needs $\sim N^2K$ variables — 32 / 300 / 900 on S / M / L — against 80 atoms (DERIVATIONS Q1); clustering needs NK. The price is a *decomposition gap* (the best clustering under our objective is not always the CVRP optimum), which we report separately in §5.

Variables and objective (brief §2). Customers $i = 1..N$ with demands d_i, K identical vehicles of capacity Q, Euclidean costs d_{ij}. One-hot $x_{ik} \in \{0, 1\}$ (customer i on vehicle k), $n = NK$ atoms: **8 / 30 / 60** on S / M / L, no slack. Objective: total pairwise distance inside each cluster, $f = \sum_k \sum_{i<j} d_{ij} x_{ik} x_{jk}$. It is additive over clusters, so an exact set-partition DP (`cvrp/exact.py`) certifies the *model* optimum on every tier.

Constraints → penalties (DERIVATIONS §4, `docs/MODEL.md`). Exactly-one [=]: squared penalty $A \sum_i (1 - \sum_k x_{ik})^2 \to h = -A$ on every variable, $J = 2A$ on each customer’s K-clique. Capacity [≤]: unbalanced penalization $\sum_k [-\lambda_1 (Q - L_k) + \lambda_2 (Q - L_k)^2]$ (Montañez-Barrera et al. 2024), expanded. Its per-customer linear part $c_i \sum_k x_{ik}$ is a *constant* on one-hot strings (the one-hot identity), so it is dropped: λ_1 disappears and what remains is $+2\lambda_2 d_i d_j$ on same-vehicle pairs, a **soft load-balance term** $\lambda_2 \sum_k L_k^2$. For $K = 2$ its optimum is capacity-feasible whenever a feasible split exists; for $K \geq 3$ only likely. We therefore score feasible decodes only and report the feasibility rate (Pitfall 9.1).

What the device sees. At $\Omega = 0$ the final Hamiltonian is a QUBO with one *uniform* linear coefficient (δ_f) and *positive* couplings (C_6/r^6) — exactly the pattern above: every $J > 0$, every $h = -A$. Weights: $A = \max_i \sum_{j \neq i} (d_{ij} + 2\lambda_2 d_i d_j) + 1$ (provable: every argmin is one-hot), $\lambda_2 = 0.15\, R/(2Q)$ from a 40-seed brute-force scan. Checker on tier S (`out/gate1/`): argmin feasible and optimal on 5/5 shipped instances; A survives one halving and fails at ¼; λ_2 is not binding on these instances.

2. Variable accounting (brief Derive 4.1)

Encoding	count	S	M	L	fits 80?
assignment variables only	NK	8	30	60	yes
+ binary slack (textbook)	$NK + K\lceil \log_2(Q+1) \rceil$	14	45	80	yes (L = cap)
ours (`onehot-ub`)	NK	**8**	**30**	**60**	yes

(`scripts/variable_count.py`; textbook rows implemented and checked, DERIVATIONS §3.) Saving: 6 / 15 / 20 atoms, none with a discarded readout; the capacity term adds no coupling pairs beyond the objective’s.

3. Embedding (DERIVATIONS §5)

What we chose, why, and what it costs. A generic least-squares placement cannot realise the one-hot rook’s graph, so we fit the register on the one-hot subspace only (§5.7). This works for $K = 2$ (tier S) and fails for $K = 3$ (tier M).

Why the generic embedder fails. The K copies of a customer form a $2A$-clique and must sit 5 µm apart, so a neighbouring customer’s atom is at nearly the same distance from all K copies: the “zero” cross-vehicle couplings come out as large as the wanted ones. Measured: rel. Frobenius error 0.95 (the brief’s formula, $\|U/\alpha - J\|_F / \|J\|_F$ over off-diagonals, always reported with the worst-pair error) and, on S_seed04, an infeasible device ground state (model optimum at device-energy rank 9).

Ask for less. On one-hot strings each customer pair contributes exactly one coupling, so only *same-vehicle minus cross-vehicle* must equal αw_{ij} (identity 5.7b); cross couplings need only be constant. Each customer becomes a rigid 5 µm K-gon (clique pinned at the minimum separation, $\alpha = C_6/5^6/2A$); centres and orientations are fitted (L-BFGS, 6 seeded starts) so that the device energies of all one-hot strings match αE_{QUBO}, with explicit single-flip defect gaps and a fitted δ_f (a constant on the subspace, so it only sets the defect gaps). Registers are cached and committed (`embeddings/`). Per run we record full-matrix and subspace fidelity and the *realised-register check*: is the device’s own argmin feasible and the model optimum, and the smallest defect gap. Tier S: 5/5 yes.

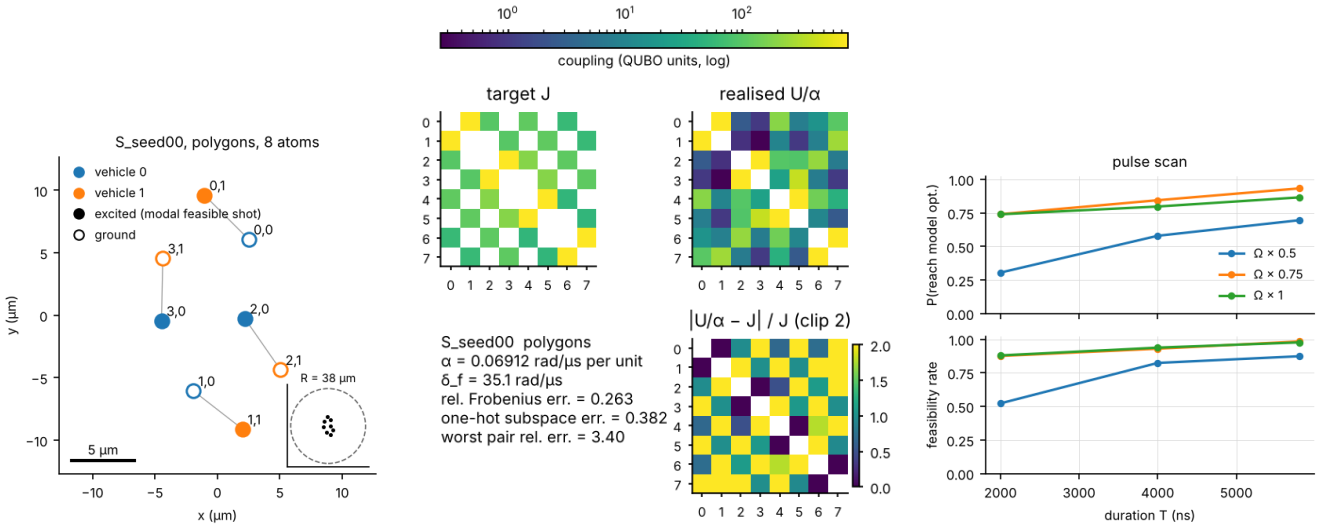


Figure 1: Left: S_seed00 register; each 5 µm dimer is one customer's exactly-one clique, filled atoms are the excited atoms of the modal feasible shot (one per dimer = a one-hot string). Middle: target vs realised couplings; clique entries are exact, cross-dimer entries are not — the full-matrix error (0.263) is dominated by what the fit does not need (worst pair 3.40), the subspace error (0.382) by what it does. Right: pulse scan on three tier-S instances (in-house SV, 500 shots, mean over instances): both curves rise with duration at every Ω, the 0.75 $\Omega_{\max}$ curve is on top at 4000 and 5800 ns, Ω/2 loses feasibility.

Where it breaks (tier M, $K = 3$). Triangles 5 µm on a side cannot be far from each other's neighbours: the subspace-fit residual is 38 (S: 0.06–0.32), defects fall below their parents and the model optimum ranks ~10 000th of 59 049 one-hot strings; opening the triangles to 6–10 µm lowers the energy scale without fixing the ordering (rank ≥ 1 279; DERIVATIONS §5.7, DID_NOT_WORK). This is the brief's §4 warning in its sharpest form, and it is a property of one-hot encodings on a 2-D $1/r^6$ register, not of the weights.

4. Pulse (DERIVATIONS §6)

Chosen: $T = 5800$ ns (device maximum minus 200 ns), $\Omega = 0.75\,\Omega_{\max}$, fitted δ_f (35–38 rad/µs on S, inside ±125.66). Shape: three-point Ω ramp (15 % / 70 % / 15 % of T) and a linear δ sweep from $\delta_0 = -\min(\max(|\delta_f|, 2\Omega_{\max}), \delta_{\max})$ to δ_f while Ω is on its plateau; every sequence is built with Pulser on `AnalogDevice` and validated (`to_abstract_repr()`, limits read from the device object). Why: a scan on three tier-S instances (Fig. 1 right, §6.6), scored by P(reach), best gap and feasibility — never mean cost. Longer is monotonically better (2000 → 4000 → 5800 ns at every Ω); $0.75\,\Omega_{\max}$ beats full and half power at 4000 and 5800 ns; $\delta_f \times \{0.8, 1, 1.25\}$ peaks at the fitted value. S_seed02/03, not used in the scan, reach the model optimum in 99 % / 96 % of shots with these settings. Emulators: pulser-simulation (qutip) for every headline row; emu-sv as a cross-check (S_seed00: P = 0.96 vs 0.94); an in-house exact state-vector integrator built from Pulser's own samples for the scans (agrees with qutip to sampling noise, TV 0.05–0.07 at 500 shots); emu-mps for M/L, bond dimension recorded.

5. Results (brief Table 3; `results.csv`, `python -m cvrp.results`)

Reading the table. One row per (instance, method); raw shots, no repair. *feas.*: fraction of shots that decode to a capacity-feasible assignment. *model gap*: best feasible shot vs the proven optimum of the clustering objective; *CVRP gap*: that shot routed exactly vs the proven CVRP optimum C^* — both on feasible decodes only, "undefined" when none exists. *P(reach C^*)*: fraction of shots whose clustering routes to C^* (so it includes the decomposition loss); *P(gap ≤ 5 %)*: fraction within 5 % of the model optimum (on these instances equal to P(reach model optimum)). *fidelity*: full-matrix rel. Frobenius error, lower is better (§3: it understates the subspace error). Rows: **ours** = headline (`onehot-ub`, polygon register, 5800 ns / 0.75 $\Omega_{\max}$, qutip); **tight A** = ablation; **random assignments (one-hot)** = the fair control (assignment-valid random strings through the same decoder); **random sampler** = uniform bitstrings; **qubo-solver quantum / tabu** = Pasqal's library on our QUBO with its own embedding and drive.

instance	method	feas.	model gap	CVRP gap	P(reach C*)	P(gap≤5%)	fidelity	backend
S_seed00	ours	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.94	0.94	0.26	qutip
S_seed00	ours, tight A (ablation)	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.03	0.03	0.31	qutip

instance	method	feas.	model gap	CVRP gap	P(reach C*)	P(gap≤5%)	fidelity	backend
S_seed00	random assign-ments (one-hot)	0.63	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.12	0.12	0.26	random-onehot
S_seed00	qubo-solver quantum	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.78	0.78	0.12	qs-quantum
S_seed00	qubo-solver tabu	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	1.00	1.00	undef.	qs-classical
S_seed00	random sampler	0.04	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.01	0.01	0.95	random
S_seed01	ours	0.95	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.95	0.95	0.21	qutip
S_seed01	ours, tight A (ablation)	0.52	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.52	0.52	0.29	qutip
S_seed01	random assign-ments (one-hot)	0.25	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.12	0.12	0.21	random-onehot
S_seed01	qubo-solver quantum	0.80	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.78	0.78	0.16	qs-quantum
S_seed01	qubo-solver tabu	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	1.00	1.00	undef.	qs-classical
S_seed01	random sampler	0.02	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.01	0.01	0.94	random
S_seed02	ours	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.99	0.99	0.31	qutip
S_seed02	qubo-solver quantum	0.95	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.18	0.18	0.21	qs-quantum
S_seed02	qubo-solver tabu	1.00	0.0 %	0.0 %	1.00	1.00	undef.	qs-classical
S_seed02	random sampler	0.04	0.0 %	0.0 %	0.01	0.01	0.31	random
S_seed03	ours	1.00	0.0 %	15.6 %	0.01	0.96	0.29	qutip
S_seed03	qubo-solver quantum	0.99	0.0 %	15.6 %	0.18	0.79	0.14	qs-quantum
S_seed03	qubo-solver tabu	1.00	0.0 %	15.6 %	0.00	1.00	undef.	qs-classical
S_seed03	random sampler	0.05	0.0 %	15.6 %	0.01	0.01	0.29	random
S_seed04	ours	1.00	0.0 %	21.7 %	0.02	0.89	0.32	qutip
S_seed04	ours, tight A (ablation)	0.99	0.0 %	21.7 %	0.02	0.94	0.34	qutip
S_seed04	random assign-ments (one-hot)	0.62	0.0 %	21.7 %	0.11	0.13	0.32	random-onehot
S_seed04	qubo-solver quantum	1.00	27.3 %	30.0 %	0.00	0.00	0.19	qs-quantum
S_seed04	qubo-solver tabu	1.00	0.0 %	21.7 %	0.00	1.00	undef.	qs-classical
S_seed04	random sampler	0.04	0.0 %	21.7 %	0.01	0.01	0.95	random

(generated by `python scripts/report_tables.py` from `results.csv`; raw shots only — repair rows are in results.csv under their own label; shots: 500 per emulator row, 2000 for the random sampler, 1 for a classical solver)

References are proven optima for every instance (exhaustive set-partition DP × exact TSP; SA and naive enumeration agree; CPLEX unavailable). Decomposition gap (model optimum routed exactly vs C^*):

instance	ρ	C* (proven)	model optimum routed exactly	decomposition gap
S_seed00	0.714	262.97	262.97	0.0 %
S_seed01	0.857	245.02	245.02	0.0 %
S_seed02	0.714	254.62	254.62	0.0 %
S_seed03	0.643	197.44	228.34	15.6 %
S_seed04	0.714	184.42	224.49	21.7 %

Reading, in four steps. (1) *Register.* On every tier-S instance the realised register's own argmin is the model optimum (device rank 1); full-matrix fidelity 0.21–0.32 against 0.94–0.95 for the generic embedder, which put the optimum at rank 9 on S_seed04. (2) *Feasibility.* 0.95–1.00 of raw shots decode to a capacity-feasible assignment (generic register: 0.06–0.22; uniform random: 0.02–0.05). (3) *P(reach) against the controls — useful quantum work (brief §9.2).* The model-optimal clustering is returned in 89–99 % of raw shots on all five instances. The fair control, `random-onehot`, reaches it with P = 2/16 ≈ 0.12 on every instance (two labelings of one optimal clustering among 16 assignments; capacity-feasible 25–63 % of the time); the headline rows give 0.94 / 0.95 / 0.89 on S_seed00/01/04 at equal decoding — a 7–8× factor, so the register, not the decoder, does the work. Uniform random bitstrings: 0.7–1.2 %; generic embedder: 3–13 %. qubo-solver's own pipeline (BLaDE + its drive shaper, 5940 ns) reaches 0.18–0.79 on four instances and a 27 % model gap on S_seed04; its tabu search finds every model optimum (its default SA path, a single-start greedy descent at $T_0 = 5$, does not — we report a stated-parameter SA instead). (4) *Decomposition.* Where P(reach C^*) is low with a 0 % model gap (S_seed03/04: 0.01 / 0.02) the loss is the decomposition gap (15.6 % / 21.7 %): the closeness objective's optimum is not the CVRP optimum. That is the cost of cluster-first (§1), not of the device.

Ablation — the exactly-one margin is physically load-bearing. `onehot-ub-tight` replaces $A = \max_i \sum_j w_{ij} + 1$ by the tight bound $A = R_w/K\,(1 + 1\%)$ (still sound: the optimum stays the QUBO ground state, checker-verified) and changes nothing else — same register construction, pulse tuned for the original A. P(reach model optimum) goes 0.94 → 0.03 on S_seed00 (the realised register's ground state becomes the third-best clustering), 0.95 → 0.52 on S_seed01 and 0.89 → 0.94 on S_seed04 (qutip; in-house SV 0.03 / 0.56 / 0.96). A smaller A shrinks the single-flip defect gaps the sweep must resolve and leaves less margin for the embedding error. The headline stays `onehot-ub`.

Tiers M and L — the measured limit of the encoding. The one-hot register does not embed for $K = 3$ (§3, DERIVATIONS Q-M1): generic and polygon registers both put the model optimum at rank ~10 000 of 59 049 one-hot strings, and a uniform random sampler decodes 0 of 2000 shots. The measured consequence on emu-mps, M_seed00 at $\chi = 32$: **0 of 500 shots feasible**, so model and CVRP gaps are undefined (STATUS, job 070; the row enters the table above as it is written to `results.csv`). M_seed01/02, L_seed00–02 ($\chi = 32$) and an M $\chi = 64$ convergence run are queued; we expect feasibility ≈ 0 and report what is measured. A $K = 2$ bisection does not rescue M/L either (`docs/GATE2_OPTIONS.md` (f): model optimum at rank 192 594 / 12 217).

6. What did not work

`docs/DID_NOT_WORK.md`, one sentence each: no PyPI from the sandboxes; CPLEX not installable; a typed number caught by review; qubo-solver's default SA; a blocking calibration job; a 12-point weight scan with no trend (the embedding optimiser's local minimum moves P(reach) more than the weights do); a non-reproducible embedding optimiser (fixed by committing registers); the tight-A ablation; the one-hot rook's graph not embedding for $K = 3$ — the honest limit of this encoding on this device.

7. Use of AI

`docs/AI_USE.md`. Claude wrote the code, the plumbing and most of the prose from the team's decisions; the Gate-1 formulation (`docs/MODEL.md`) was AI-drafted at the team's request under time pressure and checked by brute force; the team must re-derive it before judging. Every number in this report is produced by a script from committed records.